Michelle Layvant

Department of Agricultural and Resource Economics, University of California, Berkeley

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Education

University of California, Berkeley 2021–present
Ph.D. Candidate in Agricultural and Resource Economics

University of California, Berkeley 2012–2015
B.A. in Economics, Minor in Public Policy

Research Fields

Primary: Development Economics **Secondary:** Labor Economics, Behavioral Economics

References

Edward Miguel
Dept. of Economics
University of California, Berkeley
emiguel@berkeley.edu

Jeremy Magruder
Dept. of Agricultural and Resource Economics
University of California, Berkeley
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Dmitry Taubinsky
Dept. of Economics
University of California, Berkeley
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Gautam Rao
Haas School of Business & Dept. of Economics
University of California, Berkeley
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Job Market Paper

Committed to Education: School Fees, Vouchers, and the Timing of Cash Transfers
with Gonzalo Ferres Available here.

Abstract. Primary-school dropout remains widespread in Sub-Saharan Africa, and school fees are a major barrier to completion. In an experiment with 2,000 parents and children in eastern Uganda, we study whether time-inconsistent preferences help explain why fees go unpaid. We elicit parents willingness to pay for two restrictions on a cash transfer, delaying it until fees are due and, holding timing fixed, earmarking it as a voucher paid directly to the school. Demand for both restrictions is substantial: 69 percent of parents are willing to pay for earmarking and 62 percent for delay. We then randomly assign parents to receive the same amount as cash six weeks before fees are due, as cash when fees are due, as a voucher, or no transfer. The voucher more than doubles fees paid, increases school attendance, and cuts within-term dropout by more than half. Cash has smaller effects on all three outcomes, with no additional effect from delay. The vouchers effects on fee payment and attendance are largest among parents with low willingness to pay for it, in part because parents substantially underestimate how much it raises their fee payment relative to cash. In a model of quasi-hyperbolic discounting, these findings are consistent with partial naïveté, in which parents anticipate their own time inconsistency but underestimate its severity.

Working Papers

Impacts of Secondary School in Kenya after Two Decades
with Edward Miguel, Owen Ozier, and Michael Walker

Abstract. We study the long-run effects of access to secondary school in Kenya, where admission depended on a cutoff score on a national exam at the end of primary school. Using a regression discontinuity design and a panel that follows students for nearly two decades after the exam, we estimate effects on fertility, cognition, and economic outcomes. Scoring above the cutoff raises secondary school completion by 17 percentage points, with larger increases for women. We find large and persistent declines in realized fertility among men, of about one child on average, but, perhaps surprisingly, no detectable fertility effects among women. These fertility changes are not accompanied by changes in the probability of marriage. We also document durable improvements in adult cognitive performance, with gains of roughly 0.2–0.3 standard deviations. These benefits appear to extend across generations: the children of female respondents who scored above the cutoff perform better on tests of academic skills, while the children of male respondents do not. In contrast, we find limited evidence of long-run gains in earnings or household consumption.

Publications

Walker, M. W., Huang, A. H., Asman, S., Baird, S. J., Fernald, L., Hamory Hicks, J., Hoces de la Guardia, F., Koiso, S., Kremer, M., Krupoff, M. N., **Layvant, M.**, Ochieng, E., Suri, P., and Miguel, E. "Intergenerational Child Mortality Impacts of Deworming: Experimental Evidence from Two Decades of the Kenya Life Panel Survey." *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics*, forthcoming.

Ma, X., **Layvant, M.**, Miguel, E., Ochieng, E., Pillarisetti, A., and Walker, M. W. "Impacts of Contemporaneous Air Pollution Exposure on Cognitive Performance in Kenya." *Journal of Health Economics*, 109:103166, 2026.

Gross, A. L., Duhon, M., Ochieng, E., Ikanga, J. N., Dow, W. H., Lee, J., Walker, M. W., **Layvant, M.**, Ngugi, A., Ehrlich, J. R., and Miguel, E. A. "Midlife Cognitive Testing in Africa: Validity of the Harmonised Cognitive Assessment Protocol in the Kenya Life Panel Survey." *BMJ Open*, 15(8), 2025.

Grants and Fellowships

2026

Giannini Foundation of Agricultural Economics	$35,000
Rocca Dissertation Fellowship, UC Berkeley Center for African Studies	$11,000
John L. Simpson ABD Fellowship, UC Berkeley	$1,000

2025

Development Challenge Awards, Center for Effective Global Action (two awards)	$12,150; $12,000

2024

Learning for All, Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab (J-PAL)	$60,768
The Weiss Fund, University of Chicago	$39,498
CEDA Pilot Grant, Center on the Economics and Demography of Aging	$28,400
Development Challenge Award, Center for Effective Global Action	$15,000
John L. Simpson ABD Fellowship, UC Berkeley	$10,000

2023

Gender Economics Research Award, UC Berkeley Economics $9,000

Teaching

University of California, Berkeley

Business and Production of Beer, Wine, and Spirits 2021–23, 2025–26

Population, Environment, and Development 2024

Case Studies in Economic Development 2023

Research Assistance

University of California, Berkeley

Graduate Research Assistant to Edward Miguel present

Undergraduate Research Assistant to David Card 2014–2015

Center for Effective Global Action

Research Assistant to Edward Miguel 2019–2022

Partners In Health

Pro-Bono Researcher 2016–2020

Presentations

UC Berkeley: Development Lunch (2024–2026, multiple presentations), Development Workshop (2023–2026, multiple presentations), Development Department Seminar (2026), Labor Department Seminar (2026), Agricultural and Resource Economics Department Seminar (2026)

CEGA Research Retreat 2026

CEGA Evidence Action Summit 2024

Population Association of America 2024

CEGA Working Group in African Political Economy 2023

CEDA Aging in Africa 2022

Service to the Profession

Mentoring: East Africa Social Science Translation Collaborative, UC Berkeley (Spring 2023, Fall 2023)